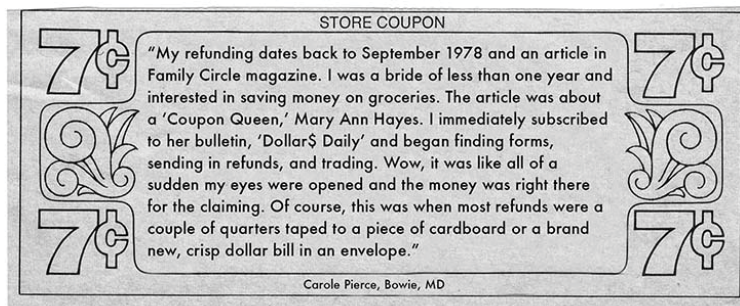


Unfortunately, all these offers that were designed to entice consumers to buy specific products by offering incentives like cash, premiums, and free coupons did something else: they enticed people to cheat.

For a group of people so eager to share their stories regarding coupon savings and memorable refund offers, I was surprised at how many clammed up when it came to the subject of refund conventions and refund fraud. One woman who excitedly shared her enthusiasm for the hobby stopped answering my e-mails when I asked about her experiences at refund conventions. She later emailed an apology and confided that she'd actually been convicted of mail fraud, fined, and put on a two years' probation. Her crime? She'd rented several PO boxes to get around the "one per address" rule of refunds.



Another woman stated that she'd personally known some of the women who were making thousands of dollars a month with refunds and who brought their cash registers with them to conventions. She minimized her own involvement, stating that she'd only had four or five PO boxes. When I asked more questions, she stopped talking. I didn't want names, only stories, yet so many seemed hesitant to share even those.